bomb (nicknamed ‘Fat Man’). Probably, few people outside Japan are familar with Kokura. They would if the weather had been different over the city on the morning of 9 August 1945. When Sweeney’s aircraft arrived over Kokura, the bomb aiming point was obscured by cloud and smoke. After three unsuccessful bomb runs over the city, the primary mission was aborted.

The plane flew to its secondary target, Nagasaki. That too was obscured by cloud and the aircraft was getting low on fuel. Instruction had been given that the bomb was only to be dropped with visual sighting of the aiming point. So, a decision was necessary whether to drop Fat Man by radar or ditch a weapon costing hundreds of millions of dollars in the sea. That decision rested with the weaponeer, Naval Commander Frederick Ashworth. Problems with a fuel tank on *Bockscar* and delays in rendezvousing with the observation aircraft meant that Major Sweeney calculated he had only fuel for one bomb run. Commander Ashworth decided to drop the bomb by radar. In the event, a hole opened in the cloud cover to enable a visual sighting. Fat Man missed its aiming point by some distance but exploded at 11.02am about 1,650ft above the slopes of the city. Its yield was estimated at twenty-two kilotons (plus or minus two).[46] Some 30–40,000 people were killed with immediate effect, rising to 70,000 by the end of 1945, and 140,000 by 1950.

It has been suggested by Stanley Goldberg that the President was unaware that a second bomb about was to be dropped.[47] That interpretation is certainly consistent with an intriguing exchange between Truman and Senator Richard Russell, who, the day after Hiroshima, sent the President a telegram urging that more bombs be dropped on Japan. On the day Nagasaki was attacked, the President replied to Russell:

> I know that Japan is a terribly cruel and uncivilized nation in warfare, but I can’t bring myself to believe that, because they are beasts, we should ourselves act in the same manner. For myself, I certainly regret the necessity of wiping out whole populations because of the ‘pigheadness’ of the leaders of a nation, and, for your information, I am not going to do it unless it is absolutely